taken time to show me the light. I will always admire him for his knowledge and his achievements, and I will always love him for his kindness.

When he spoke, I listened. I have always responded well when a friend or a coach really believed in me, and when Jacques encouraged me I instantly felt upbeat and confident.

In the first few years of my international career, while waiting to bat, I used to sit on the balcony of the changing room and watch the match because I thought it was important to be seen to be supporting the team. One day, I mentioned this to Jacques, and told him I would prefer to watch the game on television.

'Just do what you feel is right,' he told me. 'Back your instincts and you'll be fine.'

'Thanks, Oupa,' I replied.

Everybody in the squad tends to get a nickname. Shaun Pollock was 'Oupa' ('Granddad') on account of his many years of service to the team and, when Shaun retired, I worked hard to ensure the name was seamlessly transferred to Jacques Kallis; and, happily, the nickname stuck.

Oupa had spoken and that was all I needed to hear. Ever since, nine times out of 10, before going out to bat, I sit quietly in the changing room, watching TV coverage of the match, with the commentary turned down. The live broadcast is usually delayed by a few seconds, which means significant events, such as the fall of a wicket or a boundary, are signalled by the noise of the crowd outside before we see them on the screen.

This small change in routine may seem relatively insignificant but it has helped me walk out to bat in a calmer frame of mind, and it would not have happened if Jacques had not said it was OK.

The third pillar of the Proteas team was Mark Boucher, the model South African battler, brave, combative and courageous. Within the squad, he was my big brother, always looking out for me.

'Bouch' played in 147 Test matches in 14 seasons as South Africa's